

Asking about prices

Teaching guide

Ask what something costs and clarify the total.

Understand the distinction

Use How much is it? for one item and How much are they? for plural items. With cost as a verb, use does for one item: How much does it cost? The main verb stays in its base form after does.

Ask what the price includes when you need the total. Price, cost, fee, and fare fit different contexts: a course fee, a bus fare. Do not assume that a displayed amount includes every charge.

Compare the patterns

BE

How much is this notebook?

One item takes is.

COST

How much do these tickets cost?

Plural tickets take do.

CLARIFY

Does that include delivery?

Ask what is included in the stated amount.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Complete: How much ___ these shoes?

2. Correct this: How much does it costs?

3. Ask whether the price includes delivery.

Use it in your own life

Write a two-line conversation about a price and an extra charge.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. are

Shoes is plural.

2. How much does it cost?

Does carries the third-person ending; cost stays in the base form.

3. Does the price include delivery?

The question makes the total clearer.

One possible response

How much is the desk? It is eighty dollars. Does that include delivery?

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-20.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Write a two-line conversation about a price and an extra charge.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.